

2023, where it won five medals, including two gold, two silver, and one bronze. Raveendran Sankaran, Director General and CEO of the Bihar State Sports Authority, attributes the roaring success to multiple factors. "It didn't happen overnight. It took us four years. We initially concentrated on talent scouting. We empanelled the right persons for the right games, such as the Dronacharya and Arjuna awardees from across the country, who helped us identify talent. For coaching too, we had national and international awardees and Olympians mentoring our kids," he told *Sportstar*.

A lot of wrestling's history can be traced back to the *akhadas* of Haryana. Therefore, it came as no surprise when the State claimed eight of its gold medals in the sport. What's worth further praise is that Haryana's fencers won seven gold medals, indicating the state's foray into non-conventional sporting ecosystems.

Bihar tried something similar. It won both the gold medals on offer in Rugby 7s, a sport in which they have been improving by leaps and bounds for a while now. In fact, less than a month ago, the senior women's team from the State had lifted the trophy at the Nationals.

"I can't compete with Haryana in wrestling in the next 10 or maybe even 20 years. The same is true of Kerala and Tamil Nadu in basketball and volleyball. They are far ahead of us," explained Raveendran. "So, we selected such sports where not only is there potential in our athletes, but



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also where the competition is thin. But at the same time, those sports had to be part of the Olympics or Asian Games programme. Like Rugby 7s. We chose games where our medal probability would be higher."

A total of 26 records were broken at KIYG 2025, eight of them established by girls. Incidentally, five also became national youth records in weightlifting. Sairaj Pardeshi of Maharashtra accounted for three of these records himself, breaching the earlier Snatch, Clean and Jerk, and Total marks in the 81kg category.

Union Sports Minister Dr Mansukh Mandaviya elucidated how the Khelo India programme, launched on October 14, 2017, will help India realise its Olympic dream. He said, "Over the past decade, Indian sports have undergone a remarkable transformation. Under the Khelo India initiative, we have created a dynamic and inclusive sporting ecosystem with regular national-level competitions. Taking

**Victorious:** Both the men's and women's Rugby 7s teams from Bihar clinched gold medals.

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this vision forward, we will soon introduce a series of Khelo India Games throughout the year, including formats like the Khelo India Beach Games (KIBG) and others. These events will further strengthen our domestic sports structure and serve as a vital talent pipeline as we gear up for the Commonwealth Games 2030 and the Olympic Games 2036. India is on the move and the youth are at the heart of this sporting revolution."

The Khelo India caravan has hence set up camp in the picturesque Union Territory of Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu, where the inaugural KIBG — a landmark event to draw national attention to coastal and beach sports — is currently underway.

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